

The Mycenaean Saga

Where will the might of madness [*ate*] rest and end?

—AESCHYLUS, *Choephoroi*, 1075–1076



THE LEGENDS OF MYCENAE are particularly concerned with the House of Atreus and the greatest of its princes, Agamemnon, leader of the Achaeans against Troy. We consider the Trojan War later; in the present chapter, we discuss the fortunes of the house as they developed in Greece itself.

Tantalus and Pelops

The ancestor of the family of Atreus was Pelops, son of Tantalus, who came from Asia Minor as a suitor for the hand of **Hippodamia**, daughter of **Oenomaüs**, king of Pisa, whose territory included Olympia. This fact accounts for the importance of Pelops in the religious cults at Olympia. From the end of the Mycenaean Age, Pisa and Olympia were for most of the time controlled by the Peloponnesian city of Elis.

In the time of Tantalus and Pelops, there was easy intercourse between gods and mortals, and in some way Tantalus abused the privilege of eating with the gods. In the best-known version of the myth, he invited the gods to dine with him and cut up his son Pelops, boiled the parts in a cauldron, and served them at the feast. Pindar is reluctant to believe the story, but he told it nevertheless (Pindar, *Olympian Ode* 1. 47–58):

One of the envious neighbors secretly told the tale that they cut your limbs up with a knife and [put them] into the water boiling over the fire, and at the second course of the meat at the tables they divided you and ate. I cannot say that any of the blessed gods was gluttonous—I stand aside. . . . But if the guardians of Olympus honored a mortal man, that man was this Tantalus. Yet he could not digest great fortune, and in his fullness he brought on himself great madness. Thus

the Father [Zeus] balanced above him a mighty rock, and longing always to throw it away from his head, he is an exile from good cheer.

The most familiar version of Tantalus' punishment is that he was condemned to suffer everlasting thirst and hunger in the Underworld. We have given Homer's account (*Odyssey* 11. 582–592) in Chapter 15. There are two other Greek myths that involve cannibalism, both from places connected with Elis. The one is the story of Lycaon, king of Arcadia, told by Ovid (*Metamorphoses* 1. 211–243, see pp. 99–100), and the other is the banquet of Thyestes, which we discuss later in this chapter. The existence of these myths is evidence enough that in the distant past some form of cannibalism once underlay sacrificial rituals.¹

In the usual version of the myth, the gods recognized Tantalus' deception, and all, except for Demeter, refused to eat. She, it was said, ate the flesh from Pelops' shoulder, so that when he was restored to life and wholeness by the gods, an ivory shoulder had to be substituted. Pindar gives a different explanation of the temporary disappearance of Pelops, saying that Poseidon fell in love with him and took him up to Olympus, as Zeus had done with Ganymede. In any case, says Pindar, "the immortal gods sent back the son [of Tantalus] to be among the short-lived race of mortals." It was after this that Pelops traveled to Greece as the suitor of Hippodamia.

Pelops became an important hero with a cult at Olympia, where his shrine, the Pelopion, was next to the temple of Zeus. Pindar says (*Olympian Ode* 1. 90–93):

Now he lies by the crossing of the Alpheus and is present at the blood-drenched festival. He has a busy tomb, close by the altar [of Zeus] visited by multitudes.

Indeed, sacrifices to Zeus and Pelops were central to the ritual of the Olympic festival, and Pelops received a sacrifice (usually a black ram) before each sacrifice to Zeus. Not only did he give his name to the southern part of the Greek mainland, the **Peloponnese (Pelops' Island)**, but he received honors at the center of the greatest of the Panhellenic festivals. When the great temple of Zeus was built around 460 B.C. to house Pheidias' gold and ivory statue of Zeus seated upon his throne, the sculptures of the west pediment showed the moment before the start of the race between Pelops and Oenomaüs (we have described the temple on pp. 118–120).

This race was the origin of the curse on the descendants of Pelops. To win Hippodamia, a suitor had first to win a chariot race against Oenomaüs from Pisa to the Isthmus of Corinth. He would have a short start and take Hippodamia in his chariot with him; Oenomaüs would follow, and if he caught up, he would kill the suitor. Thirteen suitors had failed before Pelops came, and their heads decorated Oenomaüs' palace.

According to Pindar, Pelops prayed to his lover, Poseidon, before the race. His words give a sense of Pelops' heroic stature (*Olympian Ode* 1. 75–89):

[Pelops said] "If the dear gifts of Love, Poseidon, can be turned to good, shackle the brazen spear of Oenomaüs and bring me upon the swiftest chariot to Elis and set me near to power. For he has killed thirteen suitors and puts off his daughter's marriage. Great danger, however, does not take hold of the coward. Among those who must die, why should a man sitting in darkness pursue old age without glory, to no purpose? Before me, however, lies this contest. May you give me the action dear to me." Thus he spoke, and his words were not without

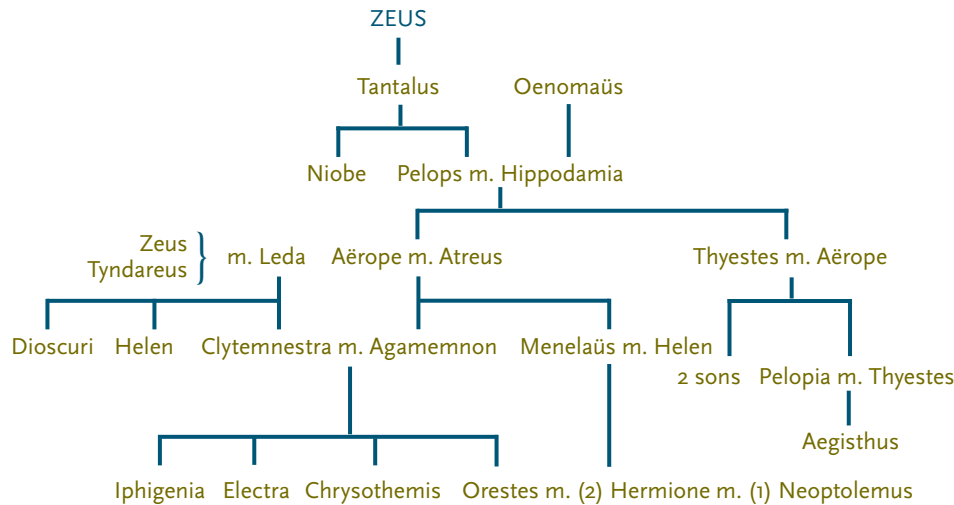


Figure 18.1. The House of Atreus

success. Honoring him, the god gave him a golden chariot and tireless winged horses. He overcame the violence of Oenomaüs and took the girl as wife. And she bore him six princes, sons eager in virtue.

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This version is simpler and probably older than the better-known one, according to which Pelops bribed Oenomaüs' charioteer, **Myrtilus** (son of the god Hermes), to remove the linchpins from Oenomaüs' chariot so that it crashed during the pursuit, killing Oenomaüs.

So Pelops won Hippodamia and drove away with her, accompanied by Myrtilus. Now Myrtilus expected that Pelops would reward him by allowing him to enjoy Hippodamia on the first night. At a resting place on the journey, he attempted to violate her, and when Pelops discovered this, he threw Myrtilus from a cliff into the sea. As Myrtilus fell, he cursed Pelops and his descendants. This curse, and the blood-guilt of the murder of Myrtilus, led to the misfortunes of the House of Atreus. Seneca, however, whose tragedy *Thyestes* is the only classical drama on this theme to survive, connects the murder with the crime of Tantalus (*Thyestes* 138–148):

Neither right nor shared crimes have prevailed. Betrayed, the master [Oenomaüs] of Myrtilus has perished, and he, meeting with the same loyalty [from Pelops] as he had shown [to Oenomaüs] has given his name to the noble sea [the Myrtoan Sea]. . . . The child Pelops, running to kiss his father, was met with the impious sword and fell, a young victim at the hearth. He was cut up by your hand, Tantalus, so that you might make a feast for your guests, the gods.

Atreus and Thyestes

Pelops returned to Pisa and became king in place of Oenomaüs. His children, Thyestes and Atreus, quarreled over the kingdom of Mycenae, which had been offered to "a son of Pelops" in obedience to an oracle. It was agreed that the possessor of a golden-fleeced ram should become king. According to Euripides

(*Electra* 698–725), Pan brought the golden-fleeced ram to Atreus, and the people of Mycenae were celebrating his succession to the throne:

The golden censers were set out, and throughout the city the altar-fires blazed. The flute, the Muses' servant, sounded its music, most beautiful. The lovely dances spread, honoring the golden ram—of Thyestes. For he had persuaded Atreus' own wife [Aërope] with secret love and took the talisman to his house. Then he came to the assembly-place and cried out that he had the horned sheep in his house, the golden-fleeced one.

Euripides further says that Zeus, in anger at Thyestes' deception, caused the sun to travel in the opposite direction. So Thyestes for a time enjoyed the reward of his adultery, and Atreus was banished. Later, Atreus returned and became king, exiling Thyestes in his turn, only to recall him and avenge himself for Aërope's seduction. He pretended to be reconciled with Thyestes and invited him to a banquet to celebrate the reconciliation. He killed Thyestes' sons and gave them to him to eat. The banquet is twice described in Seneca's *Thyestes*, first in the messenger's speech and then, in a scene of overpowering horror, through the eyes of Atreus, who, like

Adrastus and Thyestes at Sicyon. Apulian red-figure krater by the Darius painter, ca. 325 B.C.; height 25¼ in. A scene from Sophocles' (lost) tragedy *Thyestes at Sicyon*. Adrastus, king of Sicyon, central figure in the lower register, commands Thyestes (wearing a cap) to give up the baby Aegisthus to the huntsman (extreme lower left) for exposure. On the lower right, the baby's mother, Pelopia, is comforted by the queen of Sicyon, Amphihea. In the top register, Apollo (with a swan and a panther) sits in the middle looking toward a Fury (right center): Apollo had commanded the incest of Thyestes, and the Fury foreshadows the further working out of the curse on the house of Atreus if Aegisthus survives. On the right is the figure of Sicyon, representing the city bearing his name, and on the left Artemis (protectress of the young) orders Pan to see that Aegisthus is saved, perhaps (like Zeus on Crete) through being suckled by a goat. The vase shows that other traditions of the myths of Thyestes and Adrastus existed as well as those known from Aeschylus. Here Adrastus is ruler at Sicyon, having fled from Argos, and Aegisthus is born at Sicyon, where Pelopia had been sent for safety after the "banquet of Thyestes" at Argos. (Photograph © 2010. Museum of Fine Arts, Boston)



the audience in the theater, observes Thyestes as he eats the flesh of his children. Too late, Thyestes realized what he had eaten. As the heavens darkened and the sun hid from sight of the crime, Thyestes cursed Atreus and went into exile.

Agamemnon, Clytemnestra, and Aegisthus

Thus the curse of Myrtilus affected the first generation of Pelops' descendants. The quarrel of Thyestes and Atreus was continued by their sons. In his second exile, Thyestes lay with his daughter Pelopia, as he had been advised to do by an oracle, and became the father of Aegisthus, who continued the vendetta in the next generation. The son of Atreus, Agamemnon, succeeded his father as king of Mycenae. He married Clytemnestra and their children were **Iphigenia**, **Electra**, and **Orestes**; a third daughter, **Chrysothemis**, is important only as a foil for Electra in Sophocles' play (see the Additional Reading at the end of this chapter).

Agamemnon in his turn committed an unspeakable crime against one of his children. He sacrificed his daughter Iphigenia at the start of the Trojan expedition in order to appease Artemis and gain favorable winds to sail from Greece. This is one of the most powerful and pervasive of all Greek myths and was frequently represented in literature and art. It is the central myth with which Aeschylus sets forth the background to the action of his tragedy *Agamemnon* (184–249), and it is the theme of Euripides' final tragedy, *Iphigenia in Aulis* (see the painting by David on p. 484). It was narrated by the Roman poet Lucretius in a moving passage that we translate on page 484.

Agamemnon's crime earned the implacable hatred of his wife, Clytemnestra. During his absence at Troy, she committed adultery with Aegisthus, who had his own reasons to join her in plotting vengeance against Agamemnon. On his return from Troy with his prisoner, the Trojan princess **Cassandra**, Agamemnon was enticed into the palace and murdered by Clytemnestra and Aegisthus. This is the central event (although it takes place off stage) of the *Agamemnon* of Aeschylus. After the murder, Clytemnestra justifies the deed in a speech we translate later in this chapter (Aeschylus, *Agamemnon* 1372–1398). Aegisthus also took full responsibility for the deed, which he welcomed as a just vengeance upon the son of Atreus, the enemy of his father, Thyestes.

In the *Odyssey*, Agamemnon's ghost tells Odysseus how he and Cassandra were murdered (Homer, *Odyssey* 11. 408–426):

It was not brigands who murdered me on land, but Aegisthus, with my cursed wife, who killed me, arranging my death and fate, having called me into the house and given me a feast—killing me like an ox at the manger. Thus I died a most pitiable death, and around me my other companions were being ruthlessly killed, like tusked boars. . . . You have in the past experienced the death of many men, but if you had seen those deaths you would have most of all been grieved to see us lying in the hall amid the wine-bowls and tables full with food, and the whole floor flowing with blood. Most pitiable was the voice of the daughter of Priam that I heard, of Cassandra, whom treacherous Clytemnestra killed with me. But I, lifting my hands [in supplication] let them fall to the earth as I died by the sword, and my shameless wife turned away, nor did she dare, even though I was going down to the House of Hades, to close my eyes or mouth with her hands.

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In this version, Agamemnon was killed by Aegisthus and Clytemnestra at the banquet celebrating his homecoming. The more widely accepted version is



Closer Look

The Death of Agamemnon.

Attic red-figure krater by the Dokimasia painter, ca. 470 B.C.; height 20½ in. Aegisthus holds Agamemnon by his hair, having already thrust his sword into him. Agamemnon, enmeshed in a net, slips to the ground as Clytemnestra (holding an axe) runs in from the left and a woman (perhaps Electra) tries to protect Agamemnon. On the other side of this vase, the death of Aegisthus is painted. (Photograph © 2010. Museum of Fine Arts, Boston)



Audio

that of Aeschylus, in which Clytemnestra kills him in his bath, trapping him in a robe while she stabs him. Aeschylus has Cassandra foresee the murder and her own death in a dramatic prophecy before she enters the palace. She links Agamemnon's murder to the banquet of Thyestes, which she describes as if it were before her eyes (*Agamemnon* 1095–1129):

Yes, I am persuaded by the evidence I see, as I weep for these children murdered, for the cooked flesh eaten by their father. . . . What now is this new sorrow? Great is the evil being plotted in this palace, intolerable to its friends, hard to atone for, and one where defense is far away. . . . Oh, wretched woman, is this your purpose? As you wash your husband, who shares your bed, . . . how shall I describe the end? . . . What is this I see? Some net, the net of Hades? But the net is she who shares the guilt for the murder. . . . Ah! Ah! Keep the bull from the cow! She takes him in the robes and strikes him with the black-horned weapon.² He falls in the bath full of water. It is the fate brought by the bath, contriver of treacherous murder, that I describe to you.

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The prophetic cries of the inspired victim describe, as vividly as any objective report, the death of Agamemnon, which she shortly is to share. With the corpses of Agamemnon and Cassandra at her feet, Clytemnestra defends the justice of her actions. Her speech ends with the terrifying image of Clytemnestra as the earth mother being renewed by the rain of the sky-god—in this case the blood of her murdered husband. The archetypal Sacred Marriage has never been used with greater poetic effect (Aeschylus, *Agamemnon* 1372–1398):

I have said many things previously to serve my purpose, all of which I shall now contradict, without any shame. For how else could anyone fulfill hatred for an enemy who pretends to be a friend and string up nets of woe too high for him to overleap? For me this contest in this ancient quarrel has come after long planning—in the fullness of time, I say. I stand here where I struck him, over my deeds. Thus did I act, I shall not deny it, so that he could not escape or ward off his doom. I entrapped him in the fatal richness of the robe, encircling him with the huge net, like fishes. I struck him twice, and with two cries he let his limbs go slack; a third blow did I add as a thank-offering to Zeus below the earth, keeper of the dead. Thus fallen he gasped out his life, and at his dying breath he spattered me with rapid spurts, a dark-red rain of blood, and I rejoiced no less than the sown Earth rejoices in the glory of the rain that Zeus sends for the birth of the swelling buds. Thus my case rests, elders of Argos assembled, and may you too rejoice, if you would like to rejoice. As for me, I exult in my imprecations. If I had poured a libation for the corpse as would be fitting, it would have been of wine and curses—with justice, yes, with more than justice. So great were the accursed evils with which he filled our cup in the house, and now by his home-coming he drinks it to the dregs.

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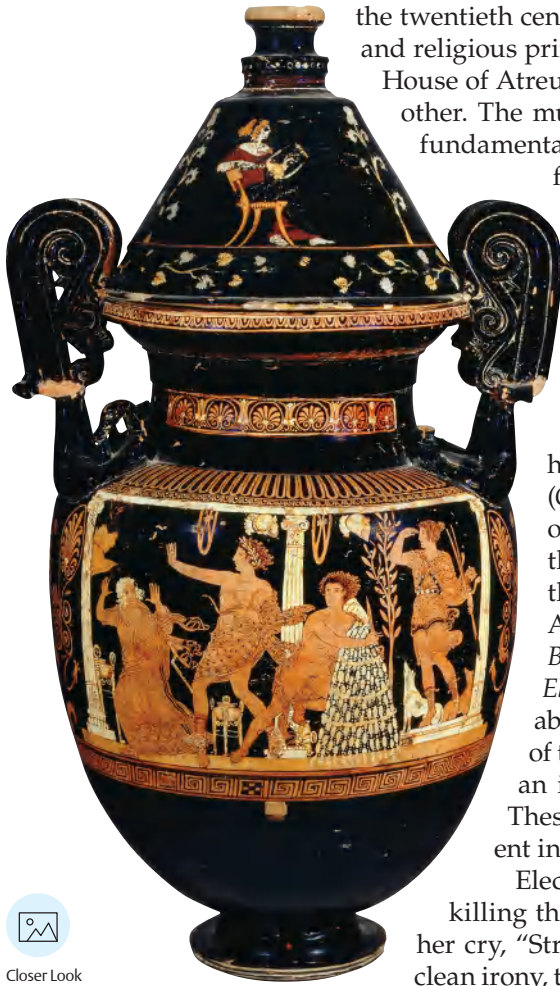
It is notable that of the sons of Atreus only Agamemnon was affected by the curse of Myrtilus. Menelaüs had his own sorrows in the adultery and flight of his wife, Helen, the cause of the Trojan War. Euripides portrays him in a contemptible light in his tragedy *Orestes*, the action of which takes place soon after Orestes has murdered Clytemnestra. He is hardly any more attractive in the *Andromache* (whose action we describe later in this chapter) or in the *Trojan Women*, whose action takes place immediately after the sack of Troy. All the literary versions of the myth portray the working out of the curse on the House of Atreus exclusively in the family of Agamemnon, whose son, Orestes, inherits its consequences.

Orestes and Electra

According to Aeschylus, Orestes was away from Mycenae at the time of Agamemnon's murder. While Clytemnestra and Aegisthus usurped the throne, he grew to manhood in exile at the court of Strophius, king of Phocis. It was now his duty to avenge the murder of his father, even though one of the murderers happened to be his own mother; and Apollo commanded him to carry out his duty. He returned to Mycenae, and with the encouragement of his sister Electra, murdered Clytemnestra and Aegisthus. In the *Odyssey*, Homer makes Zeus praise Orestes for his piety toward his dead father; and Sophocles, of the three Athenian tragedians (each of whom wrote a tragedy on the murder of Clytemnestra), is the most neutral. In both Aeschylus and Euripides, however, the feeling of revulsion at the matricide predominates. In this tradition, Orestes was pursued by the Erinyes, the Furies, the ancient divinities who avenge the victims of murder. At the end of Euripides' *Electra*, the Dioscuri prophesy that Orestes must go into exile, pursued by the Furies. Eventually, they promise, he will appeal to Athena and be acquitted of the charge of matricide by the court of the Areopagus at Athens.

These events are the subject of the *Eumenides*, the third drama in Aeschylus' trilogy *Oresteia*. The play begins at Delphi, where Orestes has come pursued by the Furies. There Apollo orders him to go to Athens, promising to protect him. At Athens Orestes pleads his case before the court of the **Areopagus**, whose members, citizens of Athens, are the jury.³ Apollo defends him, and Athena presides, while the Erinyes claim the justice of their punishment. The jury's votes are tied, and Athena gives her casting vote in favor of Orestes' acquittal, on the grounds that the killing of a mother does not outweigh the murder of a husband and father and that the son's duty toward a father outweighs all other relationships. Thus the curse on the House of Atreus comes to an end; the **Erinyes** are appeased and given a new name, the **Eumenides (Kindly Ones)**, and worshiped thereafter at Athens.

This version of the myth focuses on the development of law as the vehicle for justice, as against the ancient system (represented by the Erinyes) of blood-guilt and vengeance. But Athena's arguments are hardly persuasive, and we are left in some doubt as to whether Aeschylus himself believed in their validity. Nor is this so important as the fact that it was Zeus' will that had already determined that Orestes would be acquitted.⁴ Indeed, to Aeschylus, as to many authors, playwrights, and poets since his time (including Eugene O'Neill and T. S. Eliot in



Closer Look

Apulian red-figure krater, ca. 370 B.C.; height 35½ in. Orestes clings to the omphalos in the temple of Apollo, while Apollo wards off a Fury who flies in from the upper left. The Pythia runs off in horror from her tripod (seen between the legs of Apollo), and Artemis, on the right, with her hunting hounds, scans the heavens for more flying Furies. Various other details reinforce the setting in the temple—the three Ionic columns, the second tripod (to the left), the Pythia's key to the temple, which she is dropping, and the dedications (chariot wheels and helmets) at the top center. (*Scala/Art Resource, NY*)

the twentieth century), the legend of Orestes is important because of the moral and religious principles that it introduces. In its original form, the story of the House of Atreus is one of blood-guilt descending from one generation to another. The murder of Agamemnon is an act of vengeance, which is more fundamental to the myth than the tragic pride (*hubris*) that precedes the fall of Agamemnon, or the jealousy of Clytemnestra against Cassandra. Similarly, Orestes acted with piety in avenging his father's death; his "guilt" is a later—if more humane—interpretation. Indeed, it is illogical, for it ignores the fact that Apollo had ordered him to murder Clytemnestra. It was the genius of Aeschylus that transformed the primitive legend and, in place of the ancient doctrine of blood-guilt and vengeance, substituted the rule of reason and law.

Aeschylus presents his monumental tragic version in his trilogy *Oresteia*, consisting of *Agamemnon*, *Libation Bearers* (*Choephoroi*), and *Eumenides*. We are fortunate to have dramas of all three tragedians—Aeschylus, Sophocles, and Euripides—that deal with the events of the saga that concern Electra, the return of Orestes, and the murder of Clytemnestra and Aegisthus. These are the subjects of the second play (*Libation Bearers*) in Aeschylus' trilogy, the *Electra* of Sophocles, and the *Electra* of Euripides. Thus we are in the unique position of being able to compare the three great dramatists in their manipulation of the same plot. Each has produced a masterpiece, stamped with an individual conception of motivation, character, and religion. These three plays on an identical theme could not be more different in their personal statements and universal implications.

Electra is the focal point of Sophocles' play. Even while Orestes is killing their mother, it is Electra whom we see outside the palace with her cry, "Strike her again!" And it is Electra who, with exquisite Sophoclean irony, taunts and lures Aegisthus to his death at the hands of Orestes.

Sophocles accepts the fact that Orestes has acted justly in his obedience to Apollo's command, and he presents us with a compelling portrait of Electra, passionate in her devotion to her murdered father, consumed by hatred for her mother, Clytemnestra, and her mother's lover, Aegisthus, and kept alive by the hope that Orestes will return to mete out retribution and justice. Among the glories of Sophocles' version are a dramatic confrontation between mother and daughter and a recognition scene between brother and sister of great emotional intensity. Sophocles shows us what anger, frustration, and longing can do to the psyche of a young woman.

Even more brutal, Euripides' portrayal of Electra affords its own kind of pity and fear, tinged as it is by the sordid, realistic, and mundane. Electra's revenge, in particular, is motivated as much by sexual jealousy as by any sublime sense of absolute justice. Her monologue to the head of Aegisthus is a study in horror, and brother and sister join side by side in butchering their mother. Castor, the *deus ex machina*, with typically Euripidean philosophical ambiguity, tells us that Apollo is wise but that his orders to Orestes were not wise.

For a lengthier analysis of Aeschylus' *Libation Bearers* and the *Electras* of Sophocles and Euripides with pertinent excerpts from the texts, see the Additional Reading at the end of this chapter.

Transformations of the Legend

The legend of the *Oresteia* has inspired many works of literature. Especially memorable in the twentieth century were Eugene O'Neill's trilogy *Mourning Becomes Electra* (1931), a saga set in nineteenth-century New England, and T. S. Eliot's *The Family Reunion* (1939), where the setting is the house of an English family. John Barton has written a monumental cycle of ten plays entitled *Tantalus: An Ancient Myth for a New Millenium* (2000, an extension of an earlier work, *The Greeks*), which embraces the sagas of Mycenae and the Trojan War. In French there is, for example, Jean Giraudoux's *Electra* (1937), and Jean-Paul Sartre in his play *The Flies* transforms Orestes into a paradigm of existentialism. *The Prodigal* (1960), by the American playwright Jack Richardson, might also be mentioned.

In the ingenious novel *Angel of Light* (2004), by the American Joyce Carol Oates, Orestes and Electra have become students in Washington, D.C., descendants of the abolitionist martyr John Brown. The siblings are convinced that their father, a director in the Ministry of Justice, has been murdered by their mother. In the end, Owen (Orestes) becomes a terrorist.

It is not surprising that there are other versions of Orestes' story, which allow him to be purified from the blood-guilt by performing either some ritual or an expiatory deed, without undergoing trial and acquittal. In Euripides' play, *Iphigenia in Tauris*, not all the Erinyes have accepted the judgment of Athena, and some still pursue Orestes. Once again he comes to Delphi, where he is told by Apollo to go to the land of the **Tauri** (the modern Crimea) and fetch a wooden statue of Artemis. It was the custom of the Tauri to sacrifice strangers to Artemis in her temple, and Orestes and his companion **Pylades** (now the husband of Electra) are handed over to the priestess of Artemis, none other than Orestes' sister Iphigenia. She questions the Greek strangers about events at Argos and Mycenae and then reveals to Orestes who she is and how she has been miraculously saved at Aulis by Artemis and transported to the land of the Tauri. Once she recognizes Orestes, they deceive Thoas, king of the Tauri, into letting them take the statue of Artemis to the sea, to be cleansed of the pollution caused by Orestes, the matricide. They board Orestes' ship and set sail, but adverse wind and waves drive them back toward the land. Before Thoas can seize them, Athena appears and instructs him to let them go. So Orestes and Iphigenia return to Greece. They dedicate the statue of Taurian Artemis at Halae in Attica. Orestes returns to Mycenae, while Iphigenia stays in Attica as the priestess of Artemis at Brauron for the rest of her life.

Euripides deals with the further events in Orestes' life in two tragedies, both of which were popular in antiquity despite their complex, and sometimes incredible, plots. In the earlier tragedy, *Andromache*, produced in about 425, Menelaüs, king of Sparta, and his daughter, **Hermione**, are totally unsympathetic figures. The action is set in Phthia, over which Peleus, father of Achilles, reigns. Andromache, given as a slave to Neoptolemus, the son of Achilles, after the sack of Troy, has borne him a son, while Hermione, his wife, is childless. She, helped by Menelaüs, proposes to kill Andromache while Neoptolemus is away at Delphi;

unexpectedly, however, Peleus appears and saves her, whereupon Menelaüs shamefully leaves. At this point, Orestes appears and announces that *he* is rightfully betrothed to Hermione, whom he takes away to Argos to be his wife. Orestes has previously arranged for the murder of Neoptolemus at Delphi, and a messenger brings news of his death.

Immediately, the corpse of Neoptolemus is brought back, and as Peleus prepares to bury his grandson, Thetis appears as *deus ex machina* and announces that Neoptolemus is to be buried in the sanctuary of Apollo at Delphi (where he will be honored as a hero), and that Andromache is to go with her child to Molossia (to the northwest of Greece) and there be united with the Trojan survivor **Helenus**: it is there that Vergil brings Aeneas in the third book of the *Aeneid* to be welcomed by her and to hear the prophecy of Helenus about his own future (see p. 688). Peleus himself is to wait by the sea for the return of Thetis with her fifty Nereids: she will make him immortal, so that he can live with her forever, and he will once more see Achilles, who is not in the Underworld but in the island of Leuke.

Pindar tells rather a different story of the death of Neoptolemus (*Nemean Ode* 7. 33–47: cf. *Paean* 6. 98–120):

Neoptolemus came as a defender to the great navel of the broad-bosomed earth, when he had sacked the city of Priam, where the Danaäns had labored. He sailed from Troy past Scyros, and wandering they came to Ephyra [Corinth]. And for a short time he ruled over Molossia, and his descendants always have this honor. But he went to the god [Apollo], bringing the first fruits of the spoils from Troy. And there a man killed him with a dagger fighting over the [sacrificial] meat.

Euripides elaborates the legend of Orestes in his late tragedy *Orestes*, which was produced in 408. Its setting is outside the palace at Argos, some time after the murder of Clytemnestra. Orestes, nursed by Electra and tormented by visions of the Furies, lies in front of the palace. That very day he and Electra are to be judged by the assembly of the Argives; if they are found guilty of murder, they will be condemned to death. Menelaüs and Helen appear with Hermione, and Menelaüs refuses to help Orestes, persuaded by Tyndareus (husband of Leda, the mother of Helen and Clytemnestra), who arrives from Sparta. News of the condemnation of Orestes and Electra is brought to Electra (Orestes had defended himself in the assembly), and she and Orestes and Pylades (who has also arrived to share in his friend's fate) plot first to avenge themselves on Menelaüs by killing Helen and Hermione. Helen miraculously escapes, and Orestes and Electra appear on the roof of the palace with Hermione (against whose throat Orestes holds his sword), while Menelaüs, locked out of the palace, rages at them. Orestes now begins to set fire to the palace, and at this moment of total confusion, Apollo, serving as *deus ex machina*, appears and announces his solution to the tangled plot. Helen, he says, has been carried off to join her brothers (Castor and Polydeuces) as an immortal goddess; Orestes will go to Athens, where he will be tried and acquitted by the Areopagus, and he will marry Hermione (despite having tried to kill her!); Pylades will marry Electra.

In this way, Euripides brings to an end the saga of the House of Atreus and its curse. The younger generation (that of Orestes and Electra) is neatly paired

off, and Apollo, the god who had ordered Orestes to avenge his father's murder, restores moral, political, and social order. Yet this is very different from the solutions put forward by Aeschylus and Sophocles, and the lack of heroic dignity in any of the characters is disturbing. The ancient critic Aristophanes of Byzantium commented: "the final scene is closer to comedy. . . . The play's characters are noble in birth but its morality is utterly ignoble. For all the characters (except for Pylades) are mean." As he did in his *Electra*, Euripides, by presenting the mythical figures in an unheroic light, compels us to see how their moral dilemmas are relevant to the sordid realities of ordinary society.

The myth of Orestes ends with his ruling over Argos, Mycenae, and (through Hermione) Sparta. After his death, his bones were buried at Tegea, a city not far from Sparta and its rival in historical times. Herodotus tells how the Spartans recovered the bones and were thereafter always victorious over the Tegeans. The son of Orestes and Hermione, Tisamenus, led the Achaeans against the Heraclidae and died in battle.

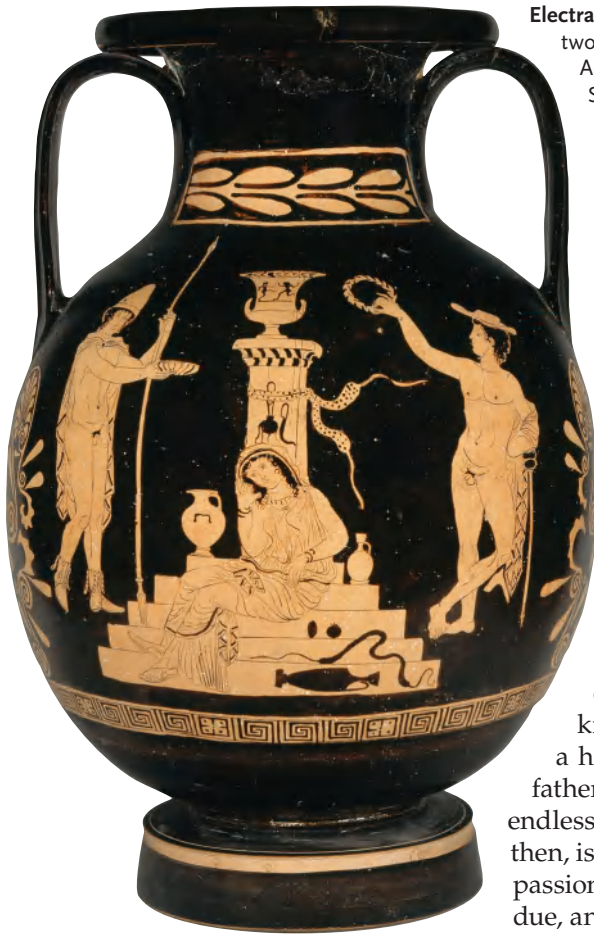
Additional Reading: Orestes and the Three Electras

Aeschylus' *Oresteia* was first produced in 458 B.C. The second play of this trilogy, *Libation Bearers* (*Choephoroi*), tells of the return of Orestes, his reunion with his sister Electra, and the murder of their mother Clytemnestra and her lover and husband Aegisthus. As has been noted in this chapter, Sophocles and Euripides also wrote plays on this same theme, affording us a unique opportunity to compare and contrast the methods and purposes of these three great dramatists. Following are some interpretative observations with translations of pertinent excerpts from each of the three plays.

Aeschylus' *Libation Bearers* (*Choephoroi*)

The play opens with Orestes, accompanied by his companion Pylades, having returned to Argos. Orestes, with a prayer to Hermes, places two locks of his hair on the tomb of his father Agamemnon. As Electra enters accompanied by a chorus of women bringing offerings to the grave, the two young men withdraw. After libations have been offered, during which Electra reveals her plight, she discovers Orestes' locks of hair and immediately recognizes them because, in texture, they are like her own. Similarly, she is convinced that Orestes has returned because the footprints that he has left match hers exactly. These signs of recognition strike the contemporary reader as dubious and extremely curious, but apparently they were used by primitive people.⁵

At this point, Orestes reveals his identity by showing a woven design on his clothing of wild animals that his sister remembers. Their recognition scene is short, swift, and joyous. To Electra, her brother brings the light and the hope of her salvation; in him alone four lost loves are restored: that of her father, her mother, her sacrificed sister, and her beloved Orestes himself. A lengthy threnody follows in which Orestes, Electra, and the Chorus elaborate on the theme of their just retribution and call upon Agamemnon, with prayers to Zeus and Apollo as well. Orestes, very much in command, reveals his plans for the murders of Aegisthus



Electra at the Tomb of Agamemnon. Lucanian *pelike* (a large vase for wine with two handles) by the Choephoroi painter, ca. 350 B.C. In this scene from Aeschylus' *Choephoroi*, Electra mourns at the tomb of her murdered father. Seated on the top step of the tomb's base, she is approached by Orestes, who is about to pour a libation, from the viewer's left, while Hermes on the right holds up a wreath. Behind Electra is a column rising from the stepped base of the tomb, with a kalix-krater on its top. Other vases (hydria on the top step; lekythoi on the second step and beside the bottom step) are evidence for Electra's repeated libations at the tomb, whose lack of success accounts for her dejected appearance. Other objects used in her offerings are shown—an egg and a pomegranate on the middle step, fillets (ribbons) tied to the column and lying on the two lower steps, and a third fillet and a tripod on the column. The vases and other objects are significant reminders of Electra's failures, while Hermes' wreath anticipates the success of Orestes' libation. (*Réunion des Musées Nationaux/Art Resource, NY*)

and Clytemnestra and gives Electra directions for her limited role in his plot. Orestes will be received into the palace and convey to Clytemnestra the false news that Orestes is dead (supposedly learned from Strophius, to whom the child Orestes had been sent).

Orestes has already disclosed the devastating power of Apollo's oracle with its dire predictions. If he does not kill to avenge Agamemnon's murder, his life will become a horror. Pursued relentlessly by the terrifying Furies of his father and covered by boils and a kind of leprosy, he will wander endlessly, an exile and pariah until he dies in misery. Orestes, then, is motivated by fear of these punishments as well as by compassion for his father, by desire to win the inheritance that is his due, and by dismay that heroes who returned from Troy with his father are now subjected to the rule of two women, Clytemnestra and the weakling Aegisthus.

Orestes and Pylades are received by Clytemnestra into the palace. She accepts the report of her son's death with intense and mixed emotions. The servant Cilissa is called upon to take the news to Aegisthus, who is away, and we learn that it was this Cilissa who nursed and cared for Orestes when he was a baby and saw to it that he got safely away after the murder of Agamemnon.

Aegisthus returns to confirm the good news and upon entering the palace meets his death at Orestes' hands. Clytemnestra will soon be next. She had sent the women with libations to the tomb of Agamemnon because, in a terrifying dream, she gave birth to a snake and nestled it to sleep in coverlets. She gave the little monster her breast to suck and cried aloud in fright and pain as it fed and tore at her nipple, drawing blood that stained the milk. Now Orestes the serpent has come to fulfill her nightmare.

A servant cries out that Aegisthus has been murdered and rouses Clytemnestra with warnings that she will be next; Clytemnestra realizes that Orestes is not dead but alive and ready to kill her (885–930):

CLYTEMNESTRA: What is the matter? What is this shouting within the palace? (885)

SERVANT: I tell you that the dead one is alive and come to strike the living dead.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Ah! I understand the meaning of your riddle. We die by treachery, just as we killed by treachery. Someone, quickly, give me an axe to kill a man. Let us see whether we win or lose. Now I have reached the critical moment in these terrible events. (887–891)

Orestes is revealed with Pylades at his side and the murdered Aegisthus at his feet (894–930):

ORESTES: It is you I am looking for. I have dealt well enough with this one here.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Alas, strong Aegisthus, dearest, are you dead? (894–895)

ORESTES: You love the man, do you? Fine, for you will lie in the same grave. Never will you be unfaithful to him now that he is dead.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Stop, my son, have reverence for this, your mother's breast, my child, from which so many times with toothless gums you drowsily sucked the milk that nourished you.

ORESTES: Pylades, what shall I do? Shouldn't I be in dread of killing my own mother?

PYLADES: What about the future and the sanctity of Apollo's oracles delivered by his holy priestess? What about binding pledges sworn in good faith? Make enemies of mortals rather than the gods. (900–902) 10

ORESTES: You overcome my fears; your advice is good. Come, mother, I want to slaughter you right next to Aegisthus here. For, when he was alive, you thought him better than my father; now sleep with him in death, since you love him and hate the man you should have loved. (903–907)

CLYTEMNESTRA: I gave life to you and I want to grow old with you.

ORESTES: You killed my father and you want to live with me?

CLYTEMNESTRA: My son, Fate had a part in all that has happened. (910)

ORESTES: Then Fate has determined what is about to happen now. 20

CLYTEMNESTRA: Aren't you afraid of the curses of a mother, my son?

ORESTES: A mother? You bore me and then threw me out to misery.

CLYTEMNESTRA: I did not throw you out but sent you away to friends.

ORESTES: I, free born, was shamefully sold out, my person and my patrimony betrayed. (915)

CLYTEMNESTRA: Where, then, is the price that I received for giving you up?

ORESTES: I blush to enumerate what you got in return, much to your shame.

CLYTEMNESTRA: You should count the sins of your father, not only mine.

ORESTES: Don't malign him, who suffered much, while you stayed safe at home. 30

CLYTEMNESTRA: It is grief for women to be without a husband, my son. (920)

ORESTES: Yet the hardships of the husband ensure the safety of the wife at home.

CLYTEMNESTRA: My son, you are going to kill your mother.

ORESTES: It is you who kill yourself, not I.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Watch out, beware the Furies, hounds of a mother's curse.

ORESTES: How can I escape the curse of my father, if I do not act? (925)

CLYTEMNESTRA: I plead for my life as though to a dead man entombed, all in vain.

ORESTES: The fate of my father brings this fate down upon you.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Ah, this is the snake that I gave birth to and nourished. 40

ORESTES: The terror of your dreams prophesied the truth. You should not have committed murder. Suffer your own murder in retaliation. (930)

A chorus comments upon the terrifying events and reiterates the themes of vengeance, justice, and the will of god. Then Orestes appears with the corpses of Aegisthus and Clytemnestra at his feet to claim that he has acted with justice. The scene parallels the one in the *Agamemnon* (with its rich and profound imagery of ensnarement, entanglement, and the net), where Clytemnestra after the murders of Cassandra and Agamemnon appears with her victims to claim that her actions have been just (p. 442). Orestes holds in his hands the very robe in which Agamemnon was entangled and butchered (973–1006):

ORESTES: Behold the two of them, tyrants of this land, murderers of my father and despoilers of his estate. Haughtily they once sat on their august thrones, lovers then and even now, as you may infer from what has befallen them. They have remained true to their pledges: together they vowed death for my poor father and swore to die together. All these things that they swore are truly accomplished. (973–979)

As you listen to my litany of their wicked deeds, look at this robe, an entanglement which they devised for my poor father as a fetter for his hands and a shackle for his feet. Spread it out, stand in a circle around it, point out this trap to ensnare her husband for father to see these unholy deeds of my mother, not my father but Helios, the Sun, the one who watches over everything so that he may bear witness for me when the time for judgment comes that I, with justice, was responsible for the fate of my mother. Aegisthus' death I need not mention, for he has received the just deserts of an adulterer according to the law. But she who devised this monstrous crime against her husband became pregnant by him; the children that she bore him she loved once, but now, as it is all too clear, they have become her dire enemy. I'll tell you what she is like. If she had been born a serpent or a viper, she would have been able to infect by touch alone, no need of fangs to bite, because of an inherent, venomous audacity. (980–996)

This robe, what am I to call it? Could I find the proper words? A trap for a wild beast, a snare for a corpse, or a covering for after the bath. One might call it a net to catch fish or one for animals or fabric to entangle the feet. The sort of thing a thief might own in order to make his living by ensnaring wayfarers and robbing them. With such a treacherous device, he could kill many, steal much, and warm his heart in comfort. (997–1004)

May I never get this kind of woman for a wife. By the will of the gods, may I die first, childless.

In the finale of the play, Orestes is driven out by the Furies, frightening, with faces like Gorgons and serpents entwined in their hair. He will find salvation in the third play, the *Eumenides* (as we have seen) through the agency of Apollo and Athena and a civil court of law. The righteous will of Zeus is eventually accomplished.

In Aeschylus' *Libation Bearers*, Orestes maintains center stage, determining the course of the action. True, a stirring and compelling portrait of Electra emerges, delineating characteristics with great potential for further development. Yet she exits from the play before Orestes and Pylades enter the palace, and her presence, therefore, does not dilute the power of a vengeance delivered by Orestes himself at the dictates of Apollo. All is as it should be for the central play of a trilogy entitled *Oresteia*.

Sophocles' *Electra*

How different are the two *Electras* that follow! We do not know for sure whether Sophocles wrote his version before or after that of Euripides; the date for Sophocles' play is unknown, and 416 B.C. for Euripides' is only a conjecture. Because of the nature of the motives and characterizations that are developed and the drastic shift in religious and philosophical sentiment, Euripides' play is best considered last.

Sophocles' *Electra* begins with the return of Orestes to Mycenae, accompanied by both his tutor and his friend Pylades, ready to set in motion his plans to exact vengeance against Aegisthus and Clytemnestra for their murder of his father, Agamemnon. In Sophocles, both are the murderers, not as in Aeschylus, where Clytemnestra did the actual deed herself. Orestes clearly and succinctly emphasizes the justice of his mission, ordained by god (32–37):

ORESTES: When I went to the Pythian oracle to find out how I should win justice from the murderers of my father, Phoebus Apollo uttered this response, which I will tell you now: I alone, without men in arms, am to steal by treachery their righteous slaughter by my own hand.

The moans of a grieving Electra are heard from within the palace, and at the tutor's urging the three leave to carry out the orders of Apollo. Thus the recognition scene between brother and sister is postponed to later in the play in order to achieve its full effect.

In her lengthy exchange with the chorus of sympathetic women, Electra reveals her misery; she cannot ever forget that her mother and her mother's bed partner split the skull of her father with an axe, much as one would cut down a mighty and regal oak. Her laments for her beloved father are endless, and her hatred for his murderers relentless; she lives only in her hope for the return of her brother and vengeance. Unmarried and alone, without children, she has become a slave and a beggar in her father's house. In her helpless isolation, she awaits the return of her brother, her savior and her salvation. She reveals her soul and her psyche in the following summation (254–309):

ELECTRA: I am ashamed, women, if it seems to you that I am too excessive in my suffering and my many complaints. Forgive me, but I am forced to act this way. How could a woman of noble integrity help but behave as I do, if she sees what I see—calamitous evils in my father's house, never ceasing causes of pain, continually fresh and renewed. (254–260)

First of all, my relationship with the mother who bore me has come to be most hateful. Then, in my own house I live with the murderers of my own father; I am ruled by them, I am dependent on them for what they give and what they take away alike. Furthermore, what kind of day do you think that I spend when I see Aegisthus sitting on the throne of my father and I behold him wearing the same clothes as he did, pouring libations at the very hearth where he killed him, and I witness the ultimate hubris, the murderer in the bed of my father, with my abominable mother—if I should call the woman who sleeps with him my mother. She is so brazen that she lives with the guilty wretch, unafraid of any retribution from any of the Furies. Instead, as though laughing exultantly at her wicked deeds, she has fixed the date on which she killed my father through



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treachery—and on this day of each month s he has established choruses and sacrifices, a holy celebration for the gods who keep her safe. (261–281)

I, however, ill fated, seeing in these halls this evil ceremonial in the name of my father, I, all alone lament, myself to myself, and weep and pine away; but I cannot indulge my grief as much as would fill my heart with joy because this queen of lies shouts wicked renunciations such as these: “Damned and hateful creature, are you the only one for whom a father has died? No other person in the world has ever been in mourning? May you go to hell and may the gods below never release you from your agonies.” (282–292)

Thus she wantonly rages, except when she hears some rumor that Orestes has returned. Then, mad with rage, she stands close beside me and yells: “Aren’t you the one responsible? Isn’t all this your doing, you, the one who stole Orestes safely out of my arms? I want you to know that you will pay the just reward that you deserve.” Such are the words she screams at me; and present by her side, he urges her on with the same reproaches, this renowned bridegroom of hers, completely impotent, an utter disaster, whose battles are only fought behind the skirts of a woman. (293–302)

I, poor wretch, waste away, waiting for Orestes to put an end to these miseries, for living in the constant expectation that he is about to accomplish this great feat, I have lost all possible hope that he will ever return. So, dear women, in such circumstances, I cannot behave with pious self-control but in the midst of these evils, necessity compels me to pursue an evil course. (303–309)

Sophocles purposefully changes Aeschylus, who has the servant Cilissa nurse the infant Orestes and whisk him away after the murder, in order to depict Electra as mother-figure to her brother.

A scene follows in which Electra encounters her sister Chrysothemis, who, as we learn, has been willing to obey Clytemnestra and Aegisthus and as a result lives freely and normally with them in the palace. Such compromise is incomprehensible and disgusting to Electra. Chrysothemis warns Electra that if she does not change her ways, she is to be sentenced upon Aegisthus’ return to spend the rest of her life imprisoned in a dungeon. We learn also that Chrysothemis has been sent to the grave of Agamemnon with libations from Clytemnestra, who has been tormented by an ambiguous dream that could foretell Orestes’ vengeance: she saw Agamemnon come to life again. He took back his royal scepter, now held by Aegisthus, and planted it in his own ground; there it burst into luxuriant leaf and quite overshadowed the whole of Mycenae.

Chrysothemis’ only importance lies in her role in Sophocles, where she is created as a dramatic foil for Electra, in much the same way as this playwright uses Ismene to illuminate by contrast the character of Antigone. Central to Sophocles’ play is a bitter and revealing confrontation between mother and daughter (516–609); there is no such scene in Aeschylus. Clytemnestra argues that Agamemnon should not have sacrificed their daughter Iphigenia. Instead, a child of Menelaüs and Helen should have been the victim at Aulis, since the Greek expedition against Troy was on behalf of Menelaüs, whose wife Helen had been abducted by the Trojan prince Paris. Electra responds with a vehement defense of her father:

CLYTEMNESTRA: It is obvious that you feel free to leave the palace and without any restraint disgrace your family and friends, since Aegisthus is not here to prevent you as he always does. But now since he is away you show me no respect.



Over and over again, for many to hear, you have spoken out that I rule brazenly and unjustly, treating you and all that you hold dear outrageously. But I am not guilty of hubris. I revile you only because you revile me so often. (516–524)

Your father is always your excuse, and nothing else—that he died by my hand. By my hand, I am well aware of that and cannot deny the charge. But Justice killed him, not I alone, and you would be on the side of Justice if you had any sense at all. Why? Because this father of yours, whom you are always bemoaning, was the only one of the Greeks to have the effrontery to sacrifice his daughter to the gods, Iphigenia, your sister. Of course it was easy enough for him to beget her, with none of the pain that I suffered when I gave her birth. So be it! Yet explain this to me. Why and for whom did he sacrifice her? Will your answer be, for the Greeks? But they had no right to kill a daughter of mine. If he killed her on behalf of his brother Menelaüs, didn't he still owe me just retribution for killing what was mine? Menelaüs had two children of his own; since the expedition against Troy was for the sake of their mother and father, wasn't it only right that they should die, instead of my daughter? Did Hades have some sort of longing for the death of a child of mine rather than one of Helen's? Did your accursed father love the children of Menelaüs and feel nothing for those that I bore to him? Isn't this the behavior of an evil, foolish father with no scruples? I think so, even if you do not. Iphigenia who is dead would agree with me, if she could speak. I am not sorry for what I have done. If you think that I am evil for feeling as I do, you had better have justice on your side before you blame others. (525–551)

ELECTRA: This time you cannot claim that I started this painful confrontation and that you were only responding to my reproaches. Yet if you will allow me, I would like to make a righteous defense on behalf of both my dead father and my sister. (552–555)

CLYTEMNESTRA: Yes, I allow you. If you always began your speeches so politely, you would not be such a pain to listen to. (556–557)

ELECTRA: Then I will speak to you. You say that you killed my father. What further admission could be more disgraceful, whether you acted justly or not? I tell you that you killed him not in justice but because you were enticed by the allurements of the evil man with whom you live. Ask the huntress Artemis what ransom she demanded for the release of the many winds which she held fast at Aulis. Since we cannot find out the answer from her, I will tell you what I have been told. Once when my father was hunting in a sacred grove of the goddess, at the sound of his footsteps a dappled stag with antlers started up. He killed it and happened to make some boast or other; at this, the daughter of Leto was enraged and detained the Achaeans until the time he would sacrifice his own daughter in compensation for the animal. Thus it was that Iphigenia was sacrificed; there was nothing else he could do so that the army could sail either homeward or to Troy. It was for this and not for Menelaüs that he sacrificed her, with great reluctance and much against his will. (558–576)

Suppose that he did perform the sacrifice out of a desire to help Menelaüs, as you argue. Did he have to die at your hands because of this? According to what kind of law? Be careful that you do not regret imposing such a law for human beings since you bring punishment down upon yourself. For if we are to commit murder in retaliation for murder, you should be the first to die, in order to satisfy the justice you deserve. But watch out that you are not making an insubstantial excuse to justify your actions. (577–584)

Tell me, if you like, for what reason you are doing the most shameful thing of all, you who sleep with the murderer with whom you once killed my father, and you who have begotten a child by him but have cast out your legitimate children born in holy wedlock.⁶ How could I sanction such behavior? Or will you say that these actions too are done in recompense for your daughter? If you do argue so, it is to your shame. For it is not right to marry the enemy, Aegisthus, for the sake of your daughter. Yet it is impossible to give good advice to you, the one who continually berates us with the charge that we speak ill of our mother, and I consider you more a tyrant than a mother toward us, I who live a life of misery, suffering many torments at the hands of you and your bedmate. Your other child far away, poor Orestes, having barely escaped your violence, wastes away his ill-starred life. Many times you have accused me of nurturing him to be your avenger. Know full well that I would have done so, if I had the power. For these reasons then denounce me to everyone, whether you proclaim me as evil or loud-mouthed or full of shamelessness. Indeed, if I am so accomplished in such behavior, it only shows that I do not in the least belie a nature and character just like yours. (585–609)

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In this way mother and daughter argue their case. The scene ends with Clytemnestra calling upon Apollo to grant that her dream might turn out well for her and that she might live a long, safe, and happy life. At the conclusion of her prayer, the tutor arrives to announce the false news of Orestes' death and set in motion the action that will end in death for Clytemnestra and Aegisthus. With similar dramatic irony, Sophocles in *Oedipus the King* marks the beginning of the end for Jocasta when the messenger from Corinth arrives immediately after her invocation to Apollo for salvation.

Belief that Orestes is dead brings Clytemnestra a joyous relief but also a painful sadness. Electra is devastated and in a second clash with Chrysothemis reveals that she is ready, all alone, to kill Aegisthus herself. Sophocles' Electra does not even contemplate the murder of her mother.

When Orestes and Pylades arrive bringing an urn that supposedly contains the ashes of the dead Orestes, Electra receives it into her hands and utters these heartbreaking words (1126–1170):

ELECTRA: This urn is a memorial of the life of Orestes, to me the most beloved of men. Here is all that is left of him. With what high hopes I sent you away, dear brother, and how far they have fallen now that I have gotten you back. Now I fondle you in my hands but you are no more. You were gloriously alive when I rescued you out of the palace. (1126–1130)

How I wish that I had died before I stole you away with these same hands and delivered you into a foreign land to save you from being murdered; if I had not done so, you could then on that day have died here, and shared death and a grave with your father. But now as it is, you have died miserably, far from home, an exile in a foreign land, separated from your sister. I, wretched me, did not bathe your corpse with loving hands or remove your remains from the blazing pyre as I should have; instead, poor brother, your funeral was in the hands of foreigners and you have come back to me as a handful of ashes in a tiny urn. Alas, unhappy me, all for nothing was the care which long ago I lavished upon you—a sweet burden; you never loved your mother more than you did me, and I was your nurse, not anyone else in the household; in addition to mother and

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nurse, you could call me your sister. But now with your death, all is over in one day. You have gone and have taken everything away with you, like a whirlwind. Father is gone, you yourself are gone and your death has killed me. Our enemies laugh and our mother is insane with joy, she no mother at all, against whom you were to appear as an avenger, as you so often promised in secret messages. But your unfortunate fate and mine have taken everything away and have sent you back to me thus—ashes, an ineffectual shade instead of the living form of my dear, dear brother. (1159) 20

Woe is me, O pitiable corpse, alas! You have been sent on a most dread journey. Welcome me to this home of yours, me your sister, whom you have destroyed—nothingness into nothingness—so that I may live with you below for the rest of time. Since I shared equally with you when I was in the upper world, now too in death I long to be given a place with you in your tomb. For I envision an end of suffering for those who are dead. (1160–1170) 30

In the recognition scene that follows, Electra, with an overwhelming joy, rushes into the arms of her brother. It is a signet-seal of his father that Orestes shows as final proof of his identity—proof more realistic, if not irrefutable, than that in Aeschylus! Orestes, her surrogate father and mother, now becomes in a sense her surrogate lover and most certainly her very real savior.

Apollo will grant Electra's prayer for success. She remains center stage while Orestes kills Clytemnestra and Aegisthus. Sophocles reverses the order of the murders with telling effect. Here is the conclusion of his play (1398–1510):

ELECTRA: Dearest women, the men will accomplish their mission at once. Just be silent and wait.

CHORUS: How now? What are they doing? (1400)

ELECTRA: She is preparing the urn for burial and the two are standing beside her.

CHORUS: Why have you hastened out of the palace?

ELECTRA: I must watch so that we may know when Aegisthus returns.

CLYTEMNESTRA: (from within the palace): Alas, the house is bereft of friends but teeming with killers. (1404–1405)

ELECTRA: Someone is crying out from within. Don't you hear, my friends? 10

CHORUS: I heard a chilling cry that makes me shudder.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Woe is me, O Aegisthus, where can you be?

ELECTRA: Listen, someone is calling out again.

CLYTEMNESTRA: My child, my child, pity your mother who bore you! (1409–1410)

ELECTRA: But he received no pity from you, and neither did his father who begat him.

CHORUS: O unfortunate city! O unhappy family! The fate that supported you daily now is waning, waning.

CLYTEMNESTRA: Ah, I am struck!

ELECTRA: Strike her again, and more deeply, if you have the strength. (1415) 20

CLYTEMNESTRA: Ah, I am struck again!

ELECTRA: I only wish Aegisthus were there too!

CHORUS: The curses are being fulfilled. Those who lie beneath the earth are alive, for those once dead are draining the blood of the murderers in retribution. Look, they are before us. A hand drips with blood from a sacrifice to Ares, and I cannot find any fault.

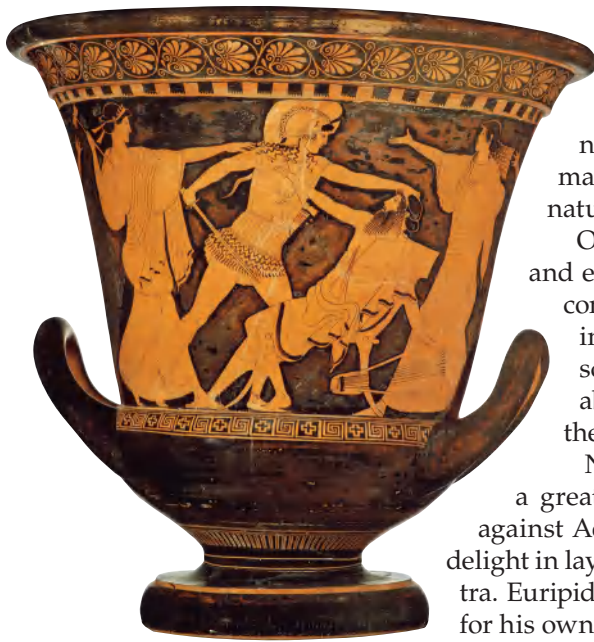
ELECTRA: Orestes, how has it turned out?
 ORESTES: It has turned out well in the house, if Apollo prophesied well. (1424–1425)
 ELECTRA: Is the wretched woman dead? 30
 ORESTES: No longer be afraid that your mother's arrogance will ever dishonor you again.
 CHORUS: Be quiet, for I see Aegisthus approaching.
 ELECTRA: Orestes and Pylades, get back.
 ORESTES: Where do you see the man? (1430–1431)
 ELECTRA: He comes towards us from the outskirts of the city, with a smile on his face.
 CHORUS: Get back inside as fast as you can so that you may take care of the situation well, as you have just done previously.
 ORESTES: Rest assured, we will do it. 40
 ELECTRA: Now hurry within. (1435)
 ORESTES: I am gone.
 ELECTRA: Let me take care of him out here.
 CHORUS: It would be a good idea for him to hear from you a few gentle words of assurance so that he may rush unsuspecting into his hidden ordeal with justice.
 AEGISTHUS: Which one of you knows the whereabouts of the strangers from Phocis, who they say have brought the news that Orestes has lost his life in the wreckage of a chariot? You, I ask you, yes you, the one always so insolent before, for I believe that his death touches you especially and you especially know about it and can answer. (1442–1447) 50
 ELECTRA: (her responses to Aegisthus are laden with dramatic irony): I know about it. How could I not know about it and remain uninformed about a calamity touching those dearest to me?
 AEGISTHUS: Then where might the strangers be? Tell me. (1450)
 ELECTRA: Within. They have greeted a loving hostess.
 AEGISTHUS: Did they bring the news that he was truly dead—for sure?
 ELECTRA: Yes, and not by word alone, but they even offered proof.
 AEGISTHUS: Is it possible for us to see this proof clearly?
 ELECTRA: We certainly can and it is a very unenviable sight. (1455) 60
 AEGISTHUS: You have said much to please me—how unusual!
 ELECTRA: May you be pleased, if this happens to give you pleasure.
 AEGISTHUS: I order that the doors be opened to display his corpse for all the Mycenaeans and Argives to see, so that if any of them were once elated by vain hopes in this man, now upon beholding him dead they may accept my bridle and learn good sense without my having to chastise them with force. (1458–1463)
 ELECTRA: Certainly I have learned this lesson; in time I have come to my senses and now acquiesce with those who are stronger.
 AEGISTHUS: (upon the revelation of the corpse): O Zeus, what I behold is a portent that has befallen not without the ill will of the gods. If it entails a just nemesis, I do not say. Remove the covering over the eyes completely so that my relative may receive proper lamentation from me. (1466–1469) 70
 ORESTES: Lift the cloth yourself; it is yours to do, not mine—to behold this face and to speak words of affection.
 AEGISTHUS: You give good advice and I will follow it. But you, call Clytemnestra, if by any chance she is in the house. (1472–1473)

- ORESTES: She is close to you; no need to look elsewhere.
- AEGISTHUS: Ah, what do I look upon?
- ORESTES: Of whom are you afraid? Whom do you not recognize? (1475)
- AEGISTHUS: Into the trap of what men have I fallen? Poor me! 80
- ORESTES: Haven't you been aware that you who are alive have been conversing face to face with the dead?
- AEGISTHUS: I understand your meaning. It cannot be otherwise; this must be Orestes who is speaking to me. (1479–1480)
- ORESTES: You the best of prophets and yet fooled for so long?
- AEGISTHUS: Wretched me, I am done for! Yet let me say a word.
- ELECTRA: Don't let him say more, brother; don't prolong all this talk, by the gods. When mortals are enmeshed in evil, what advantage is there in delay for the one who is about die? Kill him as quickly as possible, and when he is dead throw his body to scavengers for the burial he deserves, far from our sight, since 90 for me this would be the only deliverance from evil. (1483–1490)
- ORESTES: Go inside. Be quick about it. For now the contest is no longer of words but about your life.
- AEGISTHUS: Why do you force me into the palace? If your action is good, how come you need the dark and are not ready to kill me out here?
- ORESTES: Don't give orders to me. Go inside where you killed my father so that you may die in the same place. (1495–1496)
- AEGISTHUS: Is it really necessary that this house witness future as well as the present evils that have fallen upon the family of Pelops?
- ORESTES: It will witness yours, for sure. I am your unerring prophet in this. 100
- AEGISTHUS: You boast about a skill that you did not inherit from your father. (1500)
- ORESTES: Your replies are too long and our short journey is delayed. Now go.
- AEGISTHUS: Lead on.
- ORESTES: You must go first.
- AEGISTHUS: So that I may not escape you?
- ORESTES: No, so that you may not die where it pleases you. I must see to it that this is bitter for you. This swift justice should be meted out to all who desire to act outside of the laws—death, for then there would not be so much crime. 110 (1503–1507)
- CHORUS: O family of Atreus, how much you have suffered to reach freedom amid such adversity, freedom crowned by this present act of daring.

Apollo's will has been accomplished, and the justice of Zeus has been fulfilled. There are no Furies to pursue a guilty Orestes in this masterpiece that explores so profoundly the heart and the soul of a frightening, pitiable, and tragic Electra.

Euripides' *Electra*

By clever manipulation of the plot to create a different emphasis in the interpretation of the characters and their motives, Euripides seriously questions religious and philosophical beliefs about right and wrong action and the nature of justice. The setting for his play is the hut of a peasant, who is the husband of Electra. This peasant provides a prologue that gives the essential background for the plot with



The Death of Aegisthus. Athenian krater by the Dokimasia painter, ca. 470 B.C. Orestes, armed, holds Aegisthus by his hair and is about to thrust his sword into him again, for Aegisthus is already bleeding from the first blow. Clytemnestra approaches from the left with an axe, and Electra, her right hand held out, runs in from the right. Aegisthus slides from his chair as his lyre drops from his left hand and he tries to beg for mercy with his right. The other side of this vase, shown on p. 442, depicts the death of Agamemnon. (Photograph © 2010. Museum of Fine Arts, Boston)

its subtle Euripidean twists, only a few of which can be mentioned in this brief summary. Most important is the fact that Aegisthus has married off Electra to this poor but well-meaning man, in the belief that he would have nothing to fear from such a match. Indeed, Electra has remained a virgin, untouched sexually by her husband, whose nature is admirably noble.

Orestes, at the command of Apollo, returns with Pylades and encounters Electra. Eventually, their scene of recognition is confirmed most realistically. The servant who once saved the infant Orestes now, as an old man, points out to Electra a scar that proves the identity of her brother. As Electra makes abundantly clear, similarity in locks of hair and footprints or the design of woven fabric are not enough for certainty.

Now Orestes can make plans for his vengeance. He receives a great deal of assistance from the old servant for his scheme against Aegisthus, and it is Electra who takes a particularly vicious delight in laying the plot herself for the death of her mother, Clytemnestra. Euripides, like Aeschylus, places the murder of Clytemnestra last for his own macabre purposes.

The circumstances and the religious setting of the murder of Aegisthus place him in an ingratiating light. The scene is described by a messenger to a gloating Electra. Aegisthus is approached by Orestes and Pylades while he is preparing a sacrifice in honor of the nymphs, and he welcomes the strangers most hospitably as guests and friends. After he has butchered the sacrificial bull and bends over to examine the severed parts of the animal in fear of bad omens, Aegisthus is brutally stabbed in the back by Orestes, who brings his body and his severed head to his sister. Electra, painfully triumphant, addresses the remains of her most bitter enemy with the following apostrophe (907–961):

ELECTRA: Alas, first of all in reproaching you with evils, where will I begin? What sort of ending will I provide? How shall I list all those in between? To be sure, from early dawn I never ceased rehearsing the things that I wanted to say to you face to face if ever I should become free from those former terrors. Well now we are free, and I will repay you with this litany of evils which I wanted to recite to you when you were alive. (907–913)

You destroyed me and you made me and Orestes here bereft of a dear father, even though you were never wronged. You married my mother shamefully and killed her husband, commander-in-chief of the Hellenic forces against Troy, while you stayed at home. You reached such a pinnacle of folly that you expected that, having wronged my father's bed and married my mother, she would do you no wrong. Whenever anyone has corrupted the wife of another in a clandestine affair and then is compelled to marry her, let him know for sure that he is a sorry fool if he thinks that she who has already betrayed one husband will be a chaste wife for him. You lived a most abominable life, not realizing how evil it was. Yet you knew that you had entered into an unholy marriage and my mother knew that she had taken an impious man as her husband. Both of you base, each partaking of each other's evil fate, she of yours and you of hers. And among all the

10



Argives Clytemnestra never was called the wife of Aegisthus; instead you heard yourself denigrated as the husband of Clytemnestra. (914–931) 20

This is a disgrace that the woman and not the man controls the household, and I hate it when in the city children are designated not as the offspring of the male, the father, but of the mother. When a husband has married a conspicuously superior wife, the woman receives all the attention, but no account is taken of the man. But this is what deceived you, what you did not understand. You boasted that you were somebody relying on wealth for your importance. But money is nothing. It is our consort for only a little while. Nature is what remains steadfast, a good character, not money; it stays with us always and lifts away evils. But wealth, dishonest associate of the foolish, flourishes for a short time and then flies out the door. (932–944) 30

As for your affairs with women, I remain silent. Since it is not proper for a virgin to speak out about them, I will only offer discreet hints. You behaved outrageously, possessed as you were of a royal palace and endowed with physical beauty. As for me, may I get a husband who does not look like a girl but is manly, whose children would be like Ares. Good looks alone are merely a pretty adornment for devotees of the dance. (945–951)

Away with you, completely ignorant that you have paid the penalty for your crimes that have in time been found out. Let no one as wicked as you think that, if he has run the first phase of the course well, he is triumphing over Justice, before he approaches the final turn and the end of his life. (952–956) 40

CHORUS: He has done terrible things and he has paid a terrible retribution to you and Orestes because of the power of Justice.

ELECTRA: So be it. Servants, you must carry the body inside and hide it in the darkness so that when my mother arrives she may not see the corpse before she is slaughtered. (959–961)

At this point, Clytemnestra arrives upon the scene. She had been summoned with the false announcement that Electra had recently borne a son, just as Electra had planned, and, as it was with Aegisthus, her entrapment appears particularly sordid. The confrontation between mother and daughter raises similar issues that had been argued in Sophocles' version, but Euripides provides crucial additions with disturbing differences in motivation; so much of their conflict is steeped in sexual rivalry and jealousy and psychological perversity. Clytemnestra is even very much aware of the nature of Electra's complex when she observes that it is ingrained in her daughter's nature to love her father more than her mother.

Here is a much weaker Orestes than we have ever seen, who must be goaded and driven by his sister to murder their mother, and Electra herself, obsessed with a passionate hatred, actually participates in the killing.

ELECTRA: Hold on now, another decision is thrust upon us. (962)

ORESTES: What is it? Do I see an armed force coming from Mycenae?

ELECTRA: No, but the mother who gave birth to me.

ORESTES: Good! She is stepping right into the trap. (965)

ELECTRA: How splendid she looks in her fine chariot and robes.

ORESTES: What are we to do now? Will we murder our mother?

ELECTRA: Are you overcome with pity at the sight of your mother in person?



Audio

- ORESTES: Ah, how am I to kill her, the one who bore me and nourished me?
- ELECTRA: In the same way as she butchered your father and mine. (970)
- ORESTES: Oh Phoebus, you prophesied sheer folly. 10
- ELECTRA: Where Apollo is a fool, who are wise?
- ORESTES: You, Phoebus, who told me to kill my mother, a crime which I should not commit.
- ELECTRA: What possible harm is there since you are avenging your own father?
- ORESTES: I am guiltless now, but if I do the deed I will be condemned as the killer of my mother. (975)
- ELECTRA: But if you do not avenge your father, you will be impious against god.
- ORESTES: The murder of my mother—to whom will I pay the penalty?
- ELECTRA: To whom will you pay, if you fail to accomplish vengeance for your father? 20
- ORESTES: Did some demon, disguised as god, order me to do this?
- ELECTRA: A demon sitting on the sacred tripod? I really don't think so. (980)
- ORESTES: I cannot be convinced that this divine oracle was right.
- ELECTRA: Don't become a coward and a weakling.
- ORESTES: Am I to devise the same treachery against her?
- ELECTRA: Yes, the same that you used when you killed her husband Aegisthus.
- ORESTES: I will go in and undertake a terrible task. I will do a terrible thing—if the gods think it is right, so be it. This ordeal is both bitter and sweet for me. (985–987)
- CHORUS: Lady and queen of the land of Argos, daughter of Tyndareus and 30
sister of the noble twins, the sons of Zeus, who live amid the stars in the fiery firmament and are honored by mortals as their saviors in storms at sea. Greetings, I give you honor equal to the gods because of your great wealth and blessed happiness. Now is the right time for your fortunes to be provided for. Hail, O queen! (988–997)
- CLYTEMNESTRA: Out of the chariot, Trojan women, take my hand and help me to get down. The temples of the gods are adorned with Trojan spoils, and for my palace I have taken these chosen women from Troy, a small yet lovely gift, in exchange for the daughter whom I lost. (998–1003)
- ELECTRA: Shouldn't I, mother, take hold of your royal and blessed hand, for I 40
also am a slave, cast out of my ancestral home and living in a miserable one?
- CLYTEMNESTRA: I have these slaves here; don't trouble yourself on my account.
- ELECTRA: Well, am I not just like these women, taken prisoner when my palace was captured, driven out of the house, left bereft of my father? (1008–1010)
- CLYTEMNESTRA: Such are the results of actions your father devised against those whom he should have loved. I will explain. I know that when a reputation for evil clings to a woman, a bitter sharpness inevitably invests the tone of her argument. So it is with us, and that is not good. But if, upon learning the truth, you have a worthy reason to hate, it is right to hate but if not, why should there 50
be hatred? (1011–1017)
- Tyndareus gave me to your father, and the marriage was not intended to bring death to him or me or the children whom I bore. Yet that man, Agamemnon, through the pretext of marriage with Achilles, took my daughter from home and brought her to Aulis, where the fleet was kept from sailing. There he placed Iphigenia high upon the sacrificial altar and slit her white throat. If to avert the capture of his city or to benefit his house or to his other children he killed this one

girl on behalf of many, it would be forgivable. No, it was for the sake of Helen, a voracious whore, and because Menelaüs, who married her, did not know how to control his adulterous wife. This was the reason why Agamemnon murdered my daughter. And yet for all that, having been wronged, I would not have become a savage and killed my husband. But he came back to me bringing with him the maiden Cassandra, mad, possessed by god, and he brought her to our marriage bed; now there were two wives in the same household! (1018–1034) 60

Women really are foolish prey, I do not deny it. This is taken for granted, every time a husband wrongfully rejects his marriage bed for someone else. When his wife at home in her desire to follow his example takes on a lover, then all the blame is blazoned forth upon us women, but the men who are responsible hear not a word of criticism. What if Menelaüs had been secretly abducted from his home? Would it then have been necessary for me to kill Orestes so that I might rescue Menelaüs, the husband of my sister, Helen? How would your father have tolerated that crime? I would have had to suffer death at his hands for killing his son. Should he not have died for killing my daughter? Yes, and so I killed him, turning to his enemies—the only way possible. For any friend of your father would never have conspired with me in his slaughter. Speak your refutation freely, if you like, and explain how your father died unjustly. (1035–1050) 70

CHORUS: You have made a just argument, but your justice is tainted with shame. A woman who is right-minded should concede to her husband in everything. Any woman who does not think so is not included in my reckoning.

ELECTRA: Remember, mother, your last words which gave me liberty to speak. (1055–1056) 80

CLYTEMNESTRA: Yes I do, and I stand by them now, my child.

ELECTRA: After you have heard what I have to say, mother, will you treat me badly?

CLYTEMNESTRA: Not at all. I will be sweetly disposed toward you.

ELECTRA: I will speak then, and this is how I will begin. I only wish you, O you who gave me birth, were of a better mind and character. You and Helen are sisters, through and through. The physical beauty of you both is worthy of my praise, but the two of you morally are whores, and I do not consider you worthy of your noble brother Castor. Helen was willing in her rape and brought about her own ruin, and you destroyed the best man of Hellas, making up the pretext that you killed your husband because of your daughter. Those who believe you do not know you as well as I do. (1060–1068) 90

Even before the sacrifice of your daughter and when your husband had scarcely left home, you were primping before a mirror as you adorned your blonde tresses. A wife who decks herself out in beauty while her husband is away, I label a wicked woman. For she should not vaunt her fair features out of doors, unless she is looking for evil. I know for a fact that you alone of all the women of Hellas rejoiced when you heard that the Trojans were doing well, but if they were losing, your eyes would look troubled because you did not want Agamemnon to return from Troy. Yet there was every reason for you to behave properly. You had a husband in no way inferior to Aegisthus, whom Hellas chose as its commander-in-chief. Furthermore, in contrast to Helen, your sister, who did such terrible things, you could have won for yourself great renown for virtue since evil actions present a foil to enhance the good for all to see. (1069–1085) 100

If, as you say, my father killed your daughter, in what way have I or my brother done you wrong? After you killed our father, why didn't you include us in the ancestral estate? Instead, you gave what was not really yours as a dowry for your lover and bought your marriage with him. Your husband Aegisthus is not banished because of your son Orestes, nor has he died on my account, even though he has inflicted a living death upon me, twice as painful as the death of Iphigenia. If slaughter demands slaughter as a just penalty, then I and your son Orestes will kill you to avenge our father. If your actions are just, ours would be too. (1086–1096) 110

CLYTEMNESTRA: My child, it is ingrained in your nature to love your father always. This is the way things are. Some are attached to the fathers, others love their mothers more than their fathers. I will forgive you, for in truth I am not that exultant at all about the things that I have done, my daughter. But you so unwashed and so unkempt in your dress, have you just recently given birth and become a mother? Alas, poor me and my plots! I drove myself into a fury against my husband, more than I should have. (1102–1110) 120

ELECTRA: Too late for bewailing when you have no remedy for your plight. My father is dead, so why don't you recall your son who wanders far from home?

CLYTEMNESTRA: I am afraid to. I must look to my own safety, not his, since they say that he is enraged at the murder of his father. (1114–1115)

ELECTRA: Why do you allow your husband Aegisthus to treat me so cruelly?

CLYTEMNESTRA: That's the way he is; and you are inherently stubborn.

ELECTRA: I am suffering, yet I will put an end to my fury.

CLYTEMNESTRA: If so, he will persecute you no longer.

ELECTRA: He is arrogant because he lives in my house. (1120) 130

CLYTEMNESTRA: You see, you are at it again, kindling a fresh inflammatory quarrel.

ELECTRA: I'll be quiet, for I fear him, how I fear him!

CLYTEMNESTRA: Stop such talk. Why did you summon me here, my child?

ELECTRA: You have heard, I know, about the birth of my child. Make the proper sacrifice for me—I don't know how—as it is ordained for a son after he is born. I have no experience in this because until now I have been childless. (1124–1127)

CLYTEMNESTRA: This is not my duty but that of the woman who delivered the child.

ELECTRA: I gave birth alone and delivered the child myself. 140

CLYTEMNESTRA: Is your home so bereft of friendly neighbors? (1130)

ELECTRA: No one wants to have friends who are poor.

CLYTEMNESTRA: I will go and sacrifice to the gods as is appropriate after the child's birth, and when I have done this favor for you, I will go out to the countryside, where my husband is offering sacrifice to the Nymphs. Servants, take the horses out to pasture and when you think that I have finished this sacrifice to the gods, be back here, for I must also oblige my husband. (1132–1138)

ELECTRA: Enter my humble house, but be careful that the soot inside does not defile your robes, for you will make to the gods the sacrifice that you should. All is made ready, the knife that was sharpened has already slaughtered the bull, next to which you will fall after you have been struck down. Even in the house of Hades you will be joined in matrimony with the one whom you slept with in life. I will grant this favor to you and you will grant to me justice for my father. (1139–1146) 150

CHORUS: Retribution for evils. Changed gales of vengeance blow through the house. Once my king, mine, fell stricken in his bath. The stones and the rooftop shrieked with the cry that he uttered: "O wretched woman, my wife, why will you kill me who have returned to my dear fatherland after ten years?" In retribution, this unhappy woman of an adulterous marriage is brought to justice, she who took up an axe with sharpened blade and by her own hand killed her husband who had returned after many years to his home and its Cyclopean walls that reach to the sky. A poor, suffering husband, whatever evil wrong took hold of his unhappy wife. Like a lioness roaming the woods, who pastures in the mountains, she accomplished her deeds. (1147–1164) 160

CLYTEMNESTRA: (from inside the house): O my children, by the gods, do not kill your mother.

CHORUS: Do you hear her cry from within?

CLYTEMNESTRA: Ah, woe is me!

CHORUS: I pity her, overpowered and undone by her children. God metes out justice, sooner or later. You have suffered a terrible fate, but you, poor wretch, committed an unholy crime against your husband. But here they come out of the house, defiled with freshly shed blood of their mother, triumphal testimony of how they silenced her cries of anguish. No house is more lamentable than that of the family of Tantalus. (1168–1176) 170

Orestes and Electra appear, the bodies of both Aegisthus and Clytemnestra at their feet. After the horror of murdering their mother, all bravado is gone, and upon full realization of what they have done, they become craven with a remorse that is both sad and repellent. Electra must bear full responsibility for committing the crime along with Orestes; brother and sister have learned to their dismay and regret that the desire for retribution, even when ordained by the command of god, is far different emotionally and psychologically from the real trauma of actually killing their mother.

ORESTES: O Earth and Zeus, you who witness all that mortals do, behold these bloody, abominable murders, two corpses lying on the ground, struck down by my hand in recompense for my sufferings. (1177–1181)

ELECTRA: Our tears overflow, my brother, and I am the cause. In fiery rage I, poor wretch, came against this mother of mine, who bore me, her daughter.

CHORUS: Alas for misfortune, your misfortune. You, the mother who bore them, have suffered unforgettable misery and more at the hands of your children and you have paid justly for the murder of their father. (1185–1189)

ORESTES: O Phoebus, you prophesied a justice I could not foresee, but all too clear now is the misery that you have wrought. You have bestowed on me the fate of a murderer driven from this land of Hellas. To what other city will I go? What friend, what god-fearing human being will look upon the face of a man who has killed his mother? (1190–1197) 10

ELECTRA: Alas, woe is me! Where will I go? At what dance will I be accepted? What marriage will be in store for me? What husband will take me to his marriage bed?

CHORUS: Your thoughts have been changed back once again to considerations that are good. Now your thinking is holy; then it was not and you made your brother do a terrible thing, when he did not want to. (1201–1205)



Audio

ORESTES: Did you see how the poor woman opened her robe to show me her breast as I slaughtered her, alas for me, and I grabbed at her hair as her body that gave me birth sank to the floor? 20

CHORUS: I know full well the pain that you went through when you heard the piercing cry of your mother who bore you. (1210–1212)

ORESTES: This was the cry that she uttered as she touched my cheek with her hand: “My child, I beg you,” and then she clung to me so closely that my sword fell from my hand.

CHORUS: Poor woman! How did you dare to see with your own eyes your mother breathing out her life? (1218–1220)

ORESTES: I covered my eyes with my cloak as we began the sacrifice, plunging the sword into my mother’s flesh. 30

ELECTRA: I ordered you to do it as we took hold of the sword together.

CHORUS: You have done a most terrible deed.

ORESTES: Come, help me cover the limbs of our mother with her garments and close up her wounds. You gave birth to your own murderers.

ELECTRA: See how we cover you, whom we loved and we hated. (1230–1231)

The play ends with the appearance of the Dioscuri, and it is Castor who acts as the *deus ex machina*. He reaffirms religious and philosophical issues raised by Orestes himself as he hesitates in horror, while his sister is prodding him to join her in murdering their mother. To kill a mother is a terrible crime, with devastating ramifications, whether or not it is decreed by god.

CHORUS: Thus end great evils for this house. But look! Who are these two who arrive high above the house? Are they divine spirits or gods from the heavens? Mortals do not appear in this way. Why in the world do they come into the clear sight of humans? (1232–1237)

DIOSCURI (Castor speaks for the two of them): Listen, son of Agamemnon. We, Castor and Polydeuces, address you, we the twin sons of Zeus, brothers of your mother. We just now calmed a terrible storm at sea and come to Argos in time to witness here the slaughter of our sister and your mother. She received justice, but you did not act justly. And Phoebus, O Phoebus—but since he is my lord, I keep silent. Being wise, he did not prophesy to you wise things. Yet all this must be commended and now you have to do what Fate and Zeus have ordained for you. (1238–1248) 10

Castor goes on at some length to predict the future course of events, including the pursuit of Orestes by the Furies and his acquittal by the court of the Areopagus in Athens. Pylades is to marry Electra.

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Sources in the Chapter

Aeschylus	<i>Agamemnon</i> 1095–1129, 1372–1398 <i>Libation Bearers (Choephoroi)</i> 885–930, 973–1006
Euripides	<i>Electra</i> 698–725, 907–1248
Homer	<i>Odyssey</i> 11.408–426
Pindar	<i>Nemean Ode</i> 7.33–47 <i>Olympian Ode</i> 1.47–58, 175–193
Seneca	<i>Thyestes</i> 138–148
Sophocles	<i>Electra</i> (selections)

Additional Sources

Aeschylus	<i>Eumenides</i>
Euripides	<i>Iphigenia at Aulis</i> <i>Iphigenia in Tauris</i>
Herodotus	<i>History of the Persian Wars</i> 1.67.1–1.68.6 (the bones of Orestes)
Seneca	<i>Agamemnon</i>

Notes

1. These tales are brilliantly discussed by Walter Burkert, *Homo Necans* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1983), pp. 83–109, part of his chapter entitled "Werewolves around the Tripod Kettle."
2. The Greek phrase is obscure. Cassandra refers to the instrument of the murder, either a sword or an axe, one or the other of which appears in different poetic accounts and vase paintings of the murder.
3. The Areopagus was the court at Athens that heard homicide cases; its members were former archons, that is, state officials. The court had been a center of political controversy shortly before Aeschylus produced his play.
4. Apollo's argument that the child's begetter is the father and not the mother because the mother is only the nurse of the newly sown seed need not be interpreted as a manifestation of Greek misogyny, as Mary R. Lefkowitz so clearly perceives in *Women in Greek Myth* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1986), pp. 122–123: "[Apollo] is acting as an advocate for a person accused of matricide; had Orestes been accused of killing his father to avenge his mother, Apollo might well have said what Aeschylus has the Erinyes say about the primacy of maternal blood ties. The role of the female in conception, of course, was not clearly understood; opinions varied about whether the female seed present in the menstrual fluid contributed to the appearance and character of the child. . . . But no Athenian audience would have

believed that Apollo's argument was conclusive. . . . In fact, the jury in Aeschylus' drama gives Apollo and the Erinyes equal votes, and it is only because Athena, who was born from her father Zeus without a mother, casts her vote for Apollo that Orestes is acquitted."

5. For comparative examples, see George Thomson, *Aeschylus and Athens*. 3d ed. (London: Lawrence & Wishart, 1996), p. 449.
6. The child of Clytemnestra and Aegisthus was Erigone, the theme of a lost play by Sophocles and mentioned by the early cyclic poet Cinaethon.

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The Trojan Saga and the *Iliad*

A shudder in the loins engenders there
The broken wall, the burning roof and tower
And Agamemnon dead.

—W. B. YEATS, *Leda and the Swan*



LEDA, WIFE OF TYNDAREUS, king of Sparta, bore four children to Zeus, who visited her in the shape of a swan; the four were born from two eggs—from the one sprang **Polydeuces** and **Helen**, from the other **Castor** and **Clytemnestra**.

The Dioscuri

The legends of the Dioscuri (Sons of Zeus), Castor and Polydeuces (his Roman name is **Pollux**), are not part of the saga of the Trojan War. Castor was renowned as a tamer of horses, and Polydeuces was famous for his skill in boxing. Polydeuces was the immortal son of Zeus, whereas Castor was the mortal son of Tyndareus, who eventually shared in the immortality of his brother. They were perhaps originally mortal heroes, later worshiped as gods. According to Pindar, the Dioscuri quarreled with the two sons of Aphareus, **Idas** and **Lynceus**, over the division of some cattle that the four of them had taken in a raid. In the quarrel, Lynceus and Castor were killed, and Idas was destroyed by Zeus' thunderbolt. As Castor lay dying, Polydeuces prayed to Zeus that he might die with him. Zeus gave him the choice either of immortality for himself and death for Castor or of living with Castor but spending alternate days on Olympus and in Hades. Polydeuces chose the latter, and so the Dioscuri shared both immortality and death.¹